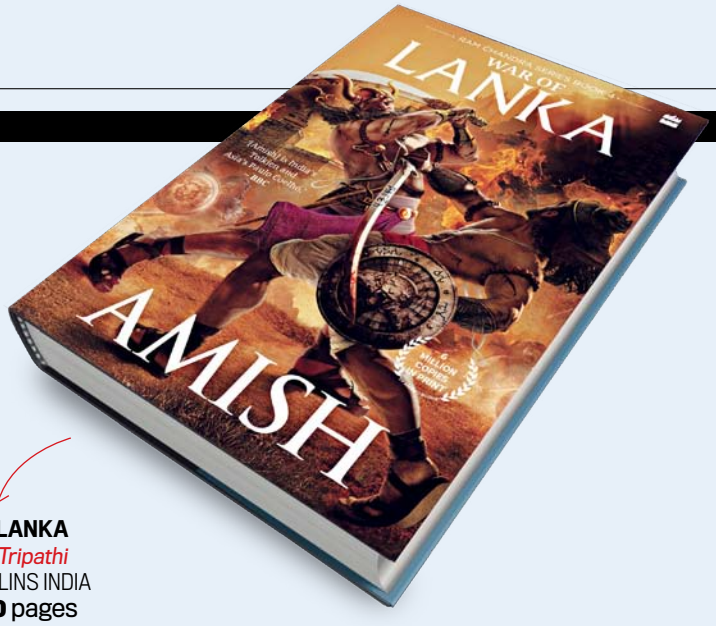


WAR OF LANKA
by Amish Tripathi
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹499; 500 pages

Sometimes it's easy to forget that Amish Tripathi, by any metric one of India's bestselling authors, began his journey with self-publishing. In 2010, after being rejected by over a dozen publishers, Tripathi published 5,000 copies of his first book *The Immortals of Meluha*, the beginning of the Shiva Trilogy. His agent paid for the printing while he invested his own money into marketing efforts. The rest, as they say, is history. Having sold millions of books, Tripathi is arguably the most sought-after English-language writer in India today. His latest novel, *War of Lanka*, is the fourth and penultimate entry in the Ram Chandra series.

Like most of Tripathi's fiction, *War of Lanka* is a re-imagination of ancient Hindu texts, in this case, the battle sections of the Ramayana. But there's a lot else besides mighty warriors and plentiful bloodshed in this book—there's also the pleasure of watching familiar-yet-different characters evolving through the course of the narrative. For example, in the Ram Chandra Series, Hanuman is the leader of the 'Naga Vayuputras', 'Naga' being the term for anyone in the imagined era who looks different (Hanuman has a flat nose and a distinctive, heavily hirsute face). We are told that Lakshman is prejudiced against Hanuman, a stance we see softening in *War of Lanka*, as the two iconic warriors fight side-by-side against the forces of evil.

"Lord Lakshman, even in the traditional versions of the Ramayana, to me, represents the beauty and simplicity of devotional loyalty," says Tripathi. "He is steadfastly loyal and devoted to his elder brother, Lord Ram. But his challenge was his lack of control over his temper. And his anger, at times, would impede his capacity for '*vivek*', that is, the ability to understand a situation with wisdom. In simple terms, Lord Lakshman was all heart. A warm open heart is a strength. But, to be more effective, one must also have a calm mind."

Tripathi's battle scenes are lush with blow-by-blow descriptions and plenty of gore—decapitations and bisections are commonplace—but also a kind of strange kineticism, as though you were watching three live sports at the same time, via split-screen. And then there's the wealth of sensory details that Tripathi floods his books with: he pays close attention to what his characters are wearing, eating and so on. At one point, we see Rama's army eating 'Maansaudan', apparently an ancient Indian dish prepared by slow-cooking rice with the flesh of quails (or other creatures).

THERE'S A LOT ELSE BESIDES **WARRIORS AND BLOODSHED IN THIS BOOK–THERE'S ALSO THE PLEASURE OF WATCHING** THE CHARACTERS EVOLVE THROUGH THE COURSE OF THE NARRATIVE

"There are many sensory details of history that I find very interesting," says Tripathi. "For example, many Indians cannot imagine Indian food without potatoes, but potatoes are not native to India. So, no ancient Indian dish mentions them. In fact, they didn't even have a word for potatoes in Vedic Sanskrit! I find these little details of food, clothes, music, etc., very interesting. It makes the places and characters in the book more real."

Around the world, we have seen bestselling authors like James Patterson and Wilbur Smith producing tonnes of new books with co-authors—they prepare plot outlines and 'polish' the first draft, which is written for them by a revolving team of younger writers. Tripathi, too, has something similar on his hands with the 'Immortal Writers Centre', who help him prepare first drafts and with his research.

"It's been a pleasure working on books with the Immortal Writers Centre," says Tripathi. "We've released two books through this process, one fiction (*Suheldev*) and one non-fiction (*Dharma*). There are many more projects being planned." Is he worried that this 'assembly line' method will change